DAILY READER

PARSHAT NOACH

No fee for the sacred, no suspicion without cause — and the tower that tried to buy its way into heaven.

Saturday, 17 October 2026 · Aliyah 7/7 (Genesis 11:1-11:32) · Daf Bekhorot 29

FROM THE LINKED SOURCES

The Rivash professionalizes Ila of Yavne

Jev score: 0.60 — Tested: does the Rivash (500:1) illuminate Bekhorot 29 non-obviously, beyond being cited by it?

The daf solves the corruption problem with incentive design: Ila the examiner is paid the same whether he rules the firstborn blemished or unblemished, so no one can suspect his ruling was bought. The Rivash (Teshuvot HaRivash 500:1), ruling on communal slaughterers, takes the daf's logic one institutional step further: let the community appoint salaried inspectors and forbid anyone else from slaughtering or inspecting in the marketplace at all — 'to distance a person from transgression and from suspicion' — even if the outsider is as expert as Ila of Yavne himself.

That is the non-obvious illumination. The daf neutralizes suspicion by fixing the wage; the Rivash neutralizes it by fixing the office. Once inspection is a communal appointment rather than a freelance gig, the question of whose wages bought whose ruling cannot even be asked. The sugya's economics of expertise becomes, five centuries later, a theory of institutions.

Rejected by Jev: Mishpetei Uziel CM 15:6 (0.51), Exodus 23:10 (0.46), Mishpetei Uziel CM 9:25 (0.44), Rosh 56:5 (0.35), Bekhorot intro essay (0.32), Rashba V 173:2 (0.31), Deuteronomy 4:5 (0.28), Proverbs 23:23 (0.20) — mostly cited-by or merely parallel.

PARSHA · NOACH

A marketplace full of חמס

Jev score: 0.61 — Tested: is the daf's corrupt-commerce theme genuinely the parsha's in miniature?

Bekhorot 29 is a portrait of commerce corrupted from within: the butcher suspected of selling firstborn meat as ordinary beef, the dealer passing off shemitta produce, the man selling teruma as weekday food. The giveaway is always in the appearances — deer meat that could be confused with calf, a hide whose cut could be passed off as mice-eaten, bleached wool masking its origins. Read beside the parsha's opening — 'the earth was filled with lawlessness (חמס)... for all flesh had corrupted its ways' — the daf's blacklist reads as the retail version of the Flood generation: not violent robbery but the quiet, systemic rot of people who can no longer tell what anything is.

And the responses rhyme too. God answers חמס with judgment and a restart; the Sages answer it with blacklists, tell-tale signs (a tanned hide proves honest labor), and incentive structures that make corruption unprofitable. Different scales, same diagnosis: when no one can trust what they're buying, the whole order has to be rebuilt.

shi: Sefaria; sources via Sefaria links. Lexicons: Klein, Jastrow, BDB via Sefaria; Maagarim via the Historical Dictionary Project of the Academy of the Hebrew Language. In the words in

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Rejected by Jev: suspicion-design/God-sorts-Noah (0.57), appearances unmasked (0.50), unpaid Noah (0.47), divine provisioning (0.36), hollowed purification waters (0.32), bekhor-as-first (0.24).

NEWS CHECK

No clean hit this week

Jev score: 0.42 — Tested 9 of the week's biggest stories against the daf's themes; strict bar, honestly applied.

Jev was strict this week and so are we. The highest score (0.42) went to Yemen, where 800,000 people are cut off from humanitarian aid as warring parties corrupt the supply lines — a distant echo of the daf's blacklisted merchants, but an analogy, not a connection. The AI-money story (Anthropic toward $350B while the daf insists Torah and judgment cannot be priced, 0.39) and the Bondi shooting aftermath (0.38) likewise gesture at the daf's themes without touching them.

The honest conclusion: nothing in this week's news genuinely resonates with Bekhorot 29's economics of sacred expertise. A section may conclude there is no connection, and this one does.

Rejected by Jev: Ukraine energy-war incentive play (0.33), Gaza's hollow ceasefire (0.28), post-catastrophe legislation (0.26), Venezuela blockade (0.18), US inflation (0.08), Taiwan arms deal (0.08) — the last two shared only a word with the daf.

MAAGARIM · SAKHAR

שכר: 6,344 attestations, from God's promise to the judge's wage

The sugya's load-bearing noun is שכר, and its Maagarim record (6,344 attestations across 243 pages) shows a word with a genuine arc. It opens in Genesis with God Himself as paymaster — 'אנכי מגן לך, שכרך הרבה מאד' (15:1), your reward shall be very great — and Leah naming Issachar for the שכר God gave her (30:18). Already in the Bible the word straddles two economies: the wage Laban haggles over with Jacob ('נקבה שכרך עלי,' 30:28) and the divine reward no one can price. The rabbis then spiritualized it into שכר מצוה — the very economy the daf polices when it voids a judge's paid rulings. And at the far end of the corpus, in Yitzhak Shami's 1937 stories, the word lands back on earth with a gloss the daf would recognize instantly: 'שכר השופט)' — the judge's wage, as customary. From God's promise to Abram to the village judge's paycheck: the whole sugya is an argument about which of these two שכרים a judge may touch.

Word data: מפעל המילון ההיסטורי של האקדמיה ללשון העברית *— the Historical Dictionary Project of the Academy of the Hebrew Language.*

929 · I KINGS 8 (CH. 295)

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A house for the Name — and the prayer that outgrew it

66 verses

The chapter is the Temple's inauguration day, and its architecture is deliberate: the ark's procession and the cloud that fills the house (1–11), Solomon's awestruck two-verse poem (12–13), the blessing that retells the Davidic promise (14–21), the great prayer (22–53), a second blessing (54–61), and then the sacrifices — twenty-two thousand oxen — with fourteen days of feasting (62–66). Every section answers the last: the cloud proves God has come, the poem names the paradox, the prayer resolves it.

On the cloud, the commentators converge. Rashi (8:12): when Solomon saw the cloud he knew the Shechinah was dwelling in the house he built — for God had promised to come 'in cloud and thick darkness' (כי בענן אראה על הכפרת, Sifrei). Metzudat David adds the philology: ערפל is the thickest cloud, as in 'אל הערפל אשר שם האלקים' (Exodus 20:18). The inauguration is legible only because Sinai already taught Israel what God's arrival looks like.

Then the poem's daring line — 'האמנם ישב אלקים את האדם על הארץ' — and Rashi's two-word gloss: האמנם is 'language of wonder'; לא יכלכלוך means לא יכילוך, they cannot contain You. Radak (8:27) turns the wonder into theology: God is 'the place of the world, and the world is not His place' (אתה מקום העולם ואין העולם מקומך). The Temple, then, is not a container but a concession — built only so that His will and glory should be present there to hear the prayer prayed in that place.

Radak's gem follows: the chosen place actually assists the prayer, 'as if the house were a defending angel (מלאך מליץ),' so that the prayer of anyone who prays there is heard sooner than prayer elsewhere. This is the chapter's answer to its own paradox — transcendence does not cancel address; it appoints one.

Malbim (8:27) finds a mutual causation humming underneath: David's merit caused God to house His Shechinah in the chosen house, and once He chose Zion and fixed His Shechinah there, He undertook to sustain the house of David for the house's sake. Temple and dynasty cause each other, each the guarantor of the other — which is why the blessing (14–21) retells the Davidic promise before the prayer begins.

The prayer's climax is the exile petition (46–53), and Radak reads its grammar closely: יחטאו כי is really וכי יחטאו — 'and if they sin' and are exiled, 'and they repent in their exile and pray toward their land, hear their prayer.' His proof text is Daniel, praying with his windows open toward Jerusalem. The directional motif — pray toward this house, this city, this land — is the chapter's great invention: prayer needs no Temple to be valid, but it needs a direction to be coherent.

Literary signature: the prayer is built on a תשמע/שמע refrain — 'hear in heaven' tolls through seven petitions (drought, famine, plague, defeat, and finally exile), each ending

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with the same cadence. Against the Chronicles parallel, where fire falls from heaven to consume the offerings, Kings keeps the fire out and lets the cloud do the work: in this telling, dedication is not sealed by spectacle but by a prayer that already anticipates the exile.

MISHNAH YOMI · OHOLOT 10:5-6

The geometry of impurity

2 mishnayot

Oholot 10:5

אֵין בָּאֲרֻבּוֹת פּוֹתֵחַ טֶפַח, טֻמְאָה בַבַּיִת, כְּנֶגֶד אֲרֻבּוֹת טָהוֹר. טֻמְאָה כְנֶגֶד אֲרֻבּוֹת, הַבַּיִת טָהוֹר. הַטֻּמְאָה בַבַּיִת, נָתַן בֵּין דָּבָר שֶׁהוּא מְקַבֵּל טֻמְאָה, בֵּין דָּבָר שֶׁאֵינוֹ מְקַבֵּל טֻמְאָה, בֵּין מִלְמַעְלָן בֵּין מִלְמַטָּן, אֵין טָמֵא אֶלָּא הַתַּחְתּוֹן. הַטֻּמְאָה כְנֶגֶד אֲרֻבּוֹת, נָתַן דָּבָר שֶׁהוּא מְקַבֵּל טֻמְאָה, בֵּין מִלְמַעְלָן בֵּין מִלְמַטָּן, הַכֹּל טָמֵא. וְדָבָר שֶׁאֵינוֹ מְקַבֵּל טֻמְאָה, בֵּין מִלְמַעְלָן בֵּין מִלְמַטָּן, אֵין טָמֵא אֶלָּא תַּחְתּוֹן:

In a case where the hatchways do not have an opening of a square handbreadth:If there is uncleanness in the house, what is directly [below] the hatchways remains clean. If there is uncleanness directly [below] the hatchways, the house remains clean. [In the case] where the uncleanness is in the house, if an article whether susceptible to uncleanness or insusceptible to uncleanness was placed either in the upper or the lower [hatchway], nothing becomes unclean except the lower story. [In the case] where the uncleanness is directly [below] the hatchways, if an article susceptible to uncleanness was placed either in the upper or lower [hatchway], everything becomes unclean. If the article is insusceptible to uncleanness, whether [it is placed] in the upper or lower [hatchway], nothing becomes unclean except the lower story.

Rambam: מבואר ממה שקדם ביאורו כאשר הבנת השרש והוא שאין טומאה נכנסת לאהל ולא יוצאה ממנו אלא בפותח טפח זה כולו:

Oholot 10:6

אֲרֻבָּה שֶׁהִיא בְתוֹךְ הַבַּיִת וּקְדֵרָה נְתוּנָה תַּחְתֶּיהָ, שֶׁאִם תֵּעָלֶה, אֵין שִׂפְתוֹתֶיהָ נוֹגְעוֹת בָּאֲרֻבָּה, טֻמְאָה תַּחְתֶּיהָ, בְּתוֹכָהּ אוֹ עַל גַּבָּהּ, טֻמְאָה בוֹקַעַת וְעוֹלָה, בוֹקַעַת וְיוֹרֶדֶת. הָיְתָה גְבוֹהָה מִן הָאָרֶץ טֶפַח, טֻמְאָה תַּחְתֶּיהָ, אוֹ בַבַּיִת, תַּחְתֶּיהָ וְהַבַּיִת, טָמֵא. תּוֹכָהּ וְגַבָּהּ, טָהוֹר. בְּתוֹכָהּ אוֹ עַל גַּבָּהּ, הַכֹּל טָמֵא:

In the case of a hatchway in a house with a pot placed below it that, if it was raised, its rims would not touch the [edges of the] hatchway: If there is uncleanness below, within or above [the pot], the uncleanness cleaves upwards and downwards. In the case where [the pot] was one handbreadth high off the ground, if there is uncleanness below it or in the house, what is below it and in the house becomes unclean, but what is within [the pot] or above it, remains clean. [If the uncleanness is] within or above [the pot], everything becomes

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unclean.

Rambam: כל מה שיהיה נכחי אליה לבד ולמעלה או למטה להיות הטומאה רצוצה ואינה תחת אהל אחד או מגולה לשמים ולא מן הארובה ולא יגע בצדדים בשום פנים וכאשר היתה הקדרה על זה המצב והיתה הטומאה באיזה שיהיה מן הקדרה הנה תטמא נוגעות בארובה ענינו שיהיה הכלי נכחי לארובה ותהיה הארובה גדולה מעצם הקדרה עד חשבנו שהכלי יעלה על עמוד נצב יצא הטומאה בתוכו או על גבה והיתה זאת הקדירה גבוהה טפח כמו שזכרנו הכל טהור ר *[יתפשט ן הגי"בד]* שאם תעלה ואין שפתיה את הטומאה וכל מה שיהיה בתוכה או על גבה הנה הוא טהור לפי שאינו תחת אהל מגולה מפני שהוא כנגד ארובה ואם היתה האהיל על הטומאה ויטמא הבית בכללו וכבר קדם לך בזה הפרק בהיות הטומאה תחת הארובה שהוא אם נתן רגלו מלמעלה עירב מעשיה ולא יראה כמו שביארנו בענין בוקעת ועולה ואם היה גובה הקדירה מן הארץ טפח וטומאה תחתיה הנה כבר תחת הקדירה טהור לפי שהוא אהל להיותה גבוהה טפח לפי מה שהשרשנו ואמנם יטמא כנגד הטומאה לבד עד לרקיע"יתפשנה ל הבית כלו טהור לפי שהטומאה כנגד הארובה וכן:

RAMBAM YOMI · HILCHOT SOTAH 2

Whom the waters will not test

16 halachot

Halachah 1

אִשָּׁה שֶׁקִּנְּאָה לָהּ וְנִסְתְּרָה אֵין כּוֹפִין אוֹתָהּ לִשְׁתּוֹת. אֶלָּא אִם רָצְתָה וְאָמְרָה הֵן נִטְמֵאתִי תֵּצֵא בְּלֹא כְּתֻבָּה וְנֶאֱסְרָה עַל בַּעְלָהּ לְעוֹלָם וְאֵינָהּ שׁוֹתָה. וְכֵן אִם אָמְרָה אֵינִי טְמֵאָה וְאֵינִי שׁוֹתָה אֵין כּוֹפִין אוֹתָהּ לִשְׁתּוֹת וְתֵצֵא בְּלֹא כְּתֻבָּה. וְכֵן אִם אָמַר בַּעְלָהּ אֵינִי רוֹצֶה לְהַשְׁקוֹתָהּ אוֹ שֶׁבָּעַל בַּעְלָהּ אַחַר שֶׁנִּסְתְּרָה הֲרֵי זוֹ אֵינָהּ שׁוֹתָה וְנוֹטֶלֶת כְּתֻבָּתָהּ וְיוֹצְאָה וְהִיא אֲסוּרָה [עָלָיו] לְעוֹלָם:

When a woman is given a warning and enters into privacy [with the man in question], she is not compelled to drink the bitter water. Instead, if she says, "I committed adultery," she is not required to drink the waters, but she must be divorced without receiving [the money due her by virtue of] her ketubah, and she is forbidden to her husband forever. Similarly, if she says: "I did not commit adultery, but I will not drink the waters," she is not forced to drink, but she must be divorced without receiving [the money due her by virtue of] her ketubah. And if her husband says, "I don't want to have her drink," or if he engaged in relations with her after she entered into privacy [with the man in question], she should not drink [the bitter water]. Instead, she is given [the money due her by virtue of] her ketubah and departs; she is forbidden to him forever.

Halachah 2

וְאֵלּוּ הֵן הַנָּשִׁים שֶׁאֵינָן רְאוּיוֹת לִשְׁתּוֹת אַף עַל פִּי שֶׁהֵן רוֹצוֹת לִשְׁתּוֹת וּבַעְלֵיהֶן רוֹצִים לְהַשְׁקוֹתָן אֶלָּא יוֹצְאוֹת בְּלֹא כְּתֻבָּה מִשֶּׁיָּבוֹאוּ עֲדֵי סְתִירָה אַחַר עֲדֵי קִנּוּי וְיֵאָסְרוּ עַל בַּעְלֵיהֶן לְעוֹלָם. וַחֲמֵשׁ עֶשְׂרֵה נָשִׁים הֵן. וְאֵלּוּ הֵן. אֲרוּסָה. וְשׁוֹמֶרֶת יָבָם. וּקְטַנָּה אֵשֶׁת הַגָּדוֹל. וּגְדוֹלָה אֵשֶׁת הַקָּטָן. וְאֵשֶׁת אַנְדְּרוֹגִינוּס. וְאֵשֶׁת הַסּוּמָא. וְאֵשֶׁת הַחֵגֶר אוֹ הָאִלֵּם. אוֹ מִי שֶׁאֵינוֹ שׁוֹמֵעַ. אוֹ שֶׁהוּא כְּרוּת יָד. וְכֵן הַחִגֶּרֶת. וְהָאִלֶּמֶת. וְהַסּוּמָא. וּכְרוּתַת יָד. וְשֶׁאֵינָהּ שׁוֹמַעַת. כָּל אַחַת מֵאֵלּוּ אֵינָהּ רְאוּיָה לִשְׁתּוֹת:

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The following women are not fit to drink [the bitter water] even though they desire to drink, and their husbands desire to have them drink. Instead, once witnesses testify that [such women] entered into privacy with the men in question after witnesses testify that a warning was granted, they are forbidden to their husbands and must be divorced without receiving [the money due them by virtue of] their ketubah. There are fifteen such women; they are: a woman who was consecrated but the marriage bond was not consummated, a yevamah who is waiting for her husband's brother to perform yibbum, a minor married to a man past the age of majority, a woman who is past majority who is married to a minor, the wife of an androgynous, the wife of a blind man, the wife of a man who limps, who cannot speak, who is deaf, or whose hand has been cut off, and similarly, a woman who limps, who cannot speak, who is blind, whose hand has been cut off, or who is deaf. All the above are not fit to drink [the bitter water].

Halachah 3

וּמִנַּיִן שֶׁאֵינָהּ רְאוּיָה לִשְׁתּוֹת שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר (במדבר ה כט) "אֲשֶׁר תִּשְׂטֶה אִשָּׁה תַּחַת אִישָׁהּ". תַּחַת פְּרָט לַאֲרוּסָה וְשׁוֹמֶרֶת יָבָם שֶׁאֵינָהּ תַּחַת אִישָׁהּ. אִשָּׁה פְּרָט לִקְטַנָּה. תַּחַת אִישָׁהּ פְּרָט לְאֵשֶׁת קָטָן וְאֵשֶׁת אַנְדְּרוֹגִינוּס שֶׁאֵינוֹ אִישׁ. (במדבר ה יג) "וְנֶעְלָם מֵעֵינֵי אִישָׁהּ" פְּרָט לְאֵשֶׁת סוּמָא. (במדבר ה יח) "וְהֶעֱמִיד הַכֹּהֵן אֶת הָאִשָּׁה" פְּרָט לְחִגֶּרֶת. (במדבר ה יח) "וְנָתַן עַל כַּפֶּיהָ" פְּרָט לְמִי שֶׁאֵין לָהּ כַּף אוֹ שֶׁהָיְתָה עֲקֻמָּה אוֹ יְבֵשָׁה שֶׁאֵינָהּ יְכוֹלָה לִקַּח בָּהּ. וַאֲפִלּוּ כַּפָּהּ אַחַת שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר כַּפֶּיהָ. וְאָמְרָה הָאִשָּׁה פְּרָט לְאִלֶּמֶת. (במדבר ה יט) "וְאָמַר אֶל הָאִשָּׁה" פְּרָט לְמִי שֶׁאֵינָהּ שׁוֹמַעַת. וַהֲרֵי הוּא אוֹמֵר אֲשֶׁר תִּשְׂטֶה אִשָּׁה תַּחַת אִישָׁהּ עַד שֶׁתִּהְיֶה שְׁלֵמָה כָּמוֹהוּ וְהוּא שָׁלֵם כְּמוֹתָהּ. הָא לָמַדְתָּ שֶׁכָּל דָּבָר שֶׁמְּעַכֵּב אוֹתָהּ מִלִּשְׁתּוֹת מְעַכֵּב אֶת בַּעְלָהּ מִלְּהַשְׁקוֹתָהּ. וְכָל הַמְעַכֵּב אֶת הַבַּעַל מִלְּהַשְׁקוֹתָהּ מוּם כָּמוֹהוּ מְעַכֵּב אוֹתָהּ מִלִּשְׁתּוֹת:

What are the sources that exclude these women from drinking [the bitter water]? [Numbers 5:29] states: "When a woman deviates [from the paths of modesty] while married to her husband...." "While married" excludes a woman who was consecrated, but the marriage bond was not consummated, and a yevamah who is waiting for her husband's brother to perform yibbum. "Her husband" excludes a minor married to a man past the age of majority. "While married to her husband" excludes a woman who is past majority who is married to a minor, and the wife of an androgynous, for he is not a man. [Numbers 5:13 states:] "And it was hidden from the eyes of her husband" - This excludes the wife of a blind man. "And the priest shall have the woman stand" [Ibid.:18] - This excludes a woman who limps. "And he shall place on her palm" [Ibid.] - This excludes a woman who does not have a hand or whose hand is crooked or shrunk to the extent that she cannot hold [the meal offering]. This applies even if only one hand is in this condition, for the verse uses the plural form of the word palm, [indicating that both hands must be fit to perform this act]. "And the woman shall say" [Ibid.:22] - This excludes a woman who cannot speak. "And he shall say to

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the woman" [Ibid.:19] - This excludes a woman who cannot hear. And [the passage continues, Ibid.:20:] "When a woman deviates [from the path of modesty] while married to her husband..." - This indicates that she must be of sound body, possessing all the physical characteristics [mentioned previously] that he possesses, and he [must possess the characteristics mentioned that she possesses]. This teaches that any physical factor that prevents her from drinking [the bitter water] prevents her husband from compelling her to drink. And any factor that prevents her husband from compelling her to drink prevents her from drinking.

Halachah 4

קְטַנָּה שֶׁהִשִּׂיאָהּ אָבִיהָ אִם זִנְּתָה בִּרְצוֹנָהּ נֶאֱסָרָה עַל בַּעְלָהּ. לְפִיכָךְ מְקַנְּין לָהּ לֹא לְהַשְׁקוֹתָהּ אֶלָּא לְפָסְלָהּ מִכְּתֻבָּתָהּ כְּמוֹ שֶׁאָמַרְנוּ. אֲבָל קְטַנָּה בַּת מֵאוֹן אֵין מְקַנְּין לָהּ שֶׁאֵין לָהּ רָצוֹן לְהֵאָסֵר עַל בַּעְלָהּ. וַאֲפִלּוּ הָיָה כֹּהֵן לֹא נֶאֱסָרָה עָלָיו:

When a minor is married off by her father, she is forbidden to her husband if she willingly commits adultery. Therefore, she is given a warning, not to compel her to drink [the bitter water], but so that she will be denied [the money due her by virtue of] her ketubah, as stated above. With regard to a minor who is entitled to nullify her marriage through mi'un, by contrast, no warning is given, for she has no desire to be forbidden to her husband. [Even if she commits adultery,] she is not forbidden to her husband, even if he is a priest.

Halachah 5

קִנֵּא לַאֲרוּסָתוֹ אוֹ לְזִקּוּקָתוֹ וְנִסְתְּרָה אַחַר שֶׁנִּשְׂאָה הֲרֵי זוֹ שׁוֹתָה כִּשְׁאָר כָּל הַנָּשִׁים. נִשּׂוֹאָה שֶׁקִּנֵּא לָהּ וְנִסְתְּרָה קֹדֶם שֶׁיִּבְעל אוֹתָהּ בַּעְלָהּ אֵינָהּ שׁוֹתָה וְיוֹצְאָה בְּלֹא כְתֻבָּה וַאֲסוּרָה עָלָיו לְעוֹלָם שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר (במדבר ה כ) "וַיִּתֵּן אִישׁ בָּךְ אֶת שְׁכָבְתּוֹ מִבַּלְעֲדֵי אִישֶׁךְ" שֶׁקְּדָמָה שְׁכִיבַת בַּעַל לִשְׁכִיבַת בּוֹעֵל:

When a man issues a warning to a woman he consecrated or to his yevamah, and she entered into privacy [with the man in question] after [the husband] consummated their marriage, she must drink [the bitter water] like any other [married] woman. When a husband issued a warning to his wife and she enters into privacy [with the man in question] before her husband engaged in sexual relations with her, she does not drink [the bitter water]. Instead, she is divorced without receiving [the money due her by virtue of] her ketubah and is forbidden to her husband forever. [This is alluded to by Numbers 5:20, which] states: "And another man has lain with you other than your husband," [implied is] that relations with the husband preceded relations with the man in question.

Halachah 6

הַגִּיֹּרֶת וְהַמְשֻׁחְרֶרֶת וְאֵשֶׁת הַגֵּר וְאֵשֶׁת עֶבֶד מְשֻׁחְרָר וּמַמְזֶרֶת וְאֵשֶׁת מַמְזֵר וְאֵשֶׁת סְרִיס חַמָּה אוֹ סְרִיס אָדָם הַמֻּתָּרוֹת לְבַעְלֵיהֶן הֲרֵי הֵן כְּכָל הַנָּשִׁים וְשׁוֹתוֹת:

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[The following women are judged] like all other married women - who are permitted to remain married - and are required to drink [the bitter water if they violated a husband's warning]: a convert, a freed maidservant, the wife of a convert, the wife of a freed servant, a woman who is of illegitimate parenthood, the wife of a man of illegitimate parenthood and the wife of an impotent man - whether he became impotent naturally or through an act of man.

Halachah 7

מְעֻבֶּרֶת וּמֵינִיקָה מְקַנֵּא לָהּ וּמַשְׁקֶה אוֹתָהּ כְּמוֹת שֶׁהִיא. אִשָּׁה הָעוֹמֶדֶת לִשְׁתּוֹת וּמֵת בַּעְלָהּ קוֹדֶם שֶׁתִּשְׁתֶּה אֵינָהּ שׁוֹתָה וְלֹא נוֹטֶלֶת כְּתֻבָּתָהּ׃

A pregnant woman and a nursing woman are required to drink [the bitter water] in their present state. When a woman is required to drink [the bitter water], but her husband dies before she has the opportunity of doing so, she should neither drink nor collect [the money due her by virtue of] her ketubah.

Halachah 8

כָּל אִישׁ שֶׁבָּא בִיאָה אֲסוּרָה מִיָּמָיו אַחַר שֶׁהִגְדִּיל אֵין הַמַּיִם הַמְאָרְרִים בּוֹדְקִין אֶת אִשְׁתּוֹ. וַאֲפִלּוּ בָּא עַל אֲרוּסָתוֹ בְּבֵית חָמִיו שֶׁאָסוּר מִדִּבְרֵי סוֹפְרִים אֵין הַמַּיִם בּוֹדְקִין אֶת אִשְׁתּוֹ שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר (במדבר ה לא) "וְנִקָּה הָאִישׁ מֵעָוֹן וְהָאִשָּׁה הַהִיא תִּשָּׂא אֶת עֲוֹנָהּ". בִּזְמַן שֶׁהָאִישׁ מְנֻקֶּה מֵעָוֹן אִשָּׁה נוֹשְׂאָה אֶת עֲוֹנָהּ׃

Whenever a man has engaged in forbidden relations from the time he attained majority onward, the curse-bearing waters do not test [the fidelity of] his wife. Even if he engaged in relations with the woman he consecrated while she was living in her father's house - which is a Rabbinic prohibition - the waters do not test [the fidelity of] his wife. [This is derived from Numbers 5:31, which] states: "The man will then be free of sin, and the woman will bear [the burden of] her sin." [Implied is that] when the man is "free of sin," "the woman will bear [the burden of] her sin."

Halachah 9

לְפִיכָךְ אִם הָיְתָה אִשְׁתּוֹ אֲסוּרָה עָלָיו מֵחֲמַת לָאוִין אוֹ מֵחֲמַת עֲשֵׂה אֲפִלּוּ שְׁנִיָּה וְקִנֵּא לָהּ וְנִסְתְּרָה אֵינָהּ שׁוֹתָה אֶלָּא תֵּצֵא בְּלֹא כְתֻבָּה וְתִהְיֶה אֲסוּרָה עָלָיו אַף מִשּׁוּם זֶה. עָבַר וְנָשָׂא מְעֻבֶּרֶת חֲבֵרוֹ וּמֵינֶקֶת חֲבֵרוֹ הֲרֵי זוֹ שׁוֹתָה שֶׁאֵין כָּאן עֲבֵרָה׃

Therefore, if a man's wife is forbidden to him because of a negative commandment, a positive commandment, or even [a Rabbinic prohibition - e.g.,] a sh'niyah, and he warned her and she entered into privacy [with the man in question], she should not drink [the bitter water]. Instead, she should be divorced and should not receive [the money due her by virtue of] her ketubah. She becomes forbidden to him for this reason as well. When a man

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transgresses and marries a woman who was made pregnant by another man, or who is nursing a child she bore by another man, she may [be compelled to] drink [the bitter water], since there is no transgression involved [in their relationship].

Halachah 10

מִי שֶׁאֵין לוֹ אִשָּׁה הָרְאוּיָה לֵילֵד וְלֹא בָּנִים וְנָשָׂא עֲקָרָה אוֹ זְקֵנָה אוֹ אֲיִלוֹנִית אֵינָהּ שׁוֹתָה וְלֹא נוֹטֶלֶת כְּתֻבָּה. הָיוּ לוֹ בָּנִים אוֹ אִשָּׁה אַחֶרֶת רְאוּיָה לֵילֵד הֲרֵי זֶה מַשְׁקֶה אוֹתָהּ אַף עַל פִּי שֶׁהִיא זְקֵנָה אוֹ עֲקָרָה אוֹ אֲיִלוֹנִית וְאֵינָהּ רְאוּיָה לֵילֵד שֶׁלֹּא נֶאֱמַר בַּתּוֹרָה (במדבר ה כח) "וְנִזְרְעָה זָרַע" אֶלָּא בִּרְאוּיָה לֵילֵד שֶׁאִם הָיְתָה יוֹלֶדֶת בְּצַעַר תֵּלֵד בְּרֶוַח. הָיָה דַּרְכָּהּ לֵילֵד נְקֵבוֹת תֵּלֵד זְכָרִים:

When a man is not married to a woman capable of bearing children, nor has he [fathered] children in [a previous marriage], and he marries a barren woman, a woman past the age of child-bearing or an aylonit, [the marriage is not considered desirable in the eyes of the Sages]. [Therefore,] such a woman may not drink [the bitter water], nor does she receive [the money due her by virtue of] her ketubah [if the husband divorces her for violating his warning]. If, however, [the husband] has [already fathered] children, or he has another wife capable of bearing children, he may compel [his other wife] to drink [the bitter water] even if she is past the age of child-bearing, barren or an aylonit, and thus incapable of giving birth. For the Torah's statement, [Numbers 5:28] "And she will be cleared and she will conceive" applies solely to a woman capable of giving birth, [implying] that if previously she would give birth in pain, she will give birth comfortably; if previously she would give birth to daughters, she will give birth to sons.

Halachah 11

הָיוּ לוֹ אִשָּׁה וּבָנִים וּמֵתוּ בֵּין קִנּוּי לִסְתִירָה כְּבָר נִרְאֵית לִשְׁתּוֹת וּמַשְׁקֶה אוֹתָהּ. לֹא הָיוּ לוֹ בָּנִים וְלֹא אִשָּׁה הָרְאוּיָה לֵילֵד אֶלָּא זוֹ הָאֲיִלוֹנִית וְכִיּוֹצֵא בָּהּ וְנוֹלַד לוֹ בֵּן מִגְּרוּשָׁתוֹ בֵּין קִנּוּי לִסְתִירָה כְּבָר נִדְחֵית הָאֲיִלוֹנִית מִלִּשְׁתּוֹת:

If [a husband] had [another] wife [capable of bearing children] or had children, but they died between the time when the warning was issued and the time the woman entered into privacy [with the man in question], the woman was already fit to drink the bitter water, and she should be compelled to drink. If [a husband] did not have children or [another] wife capable of bearing children aside from an aylonit or another woman [incapable of bearing children], and his divorcee bore him a son between the time when the warning was issued and the time the woman entered into privacy [with the man in question], the aylonit was already excluded from drinking [and that ruling remains].

Halachah 12

כָּל אִשָּׁה שֶׁהָיְתָה לָהּ קִנּוּי וּסְתִירָה וְלֹא שָׁתְתָה מֵי הַמָּרִים בֵּין שֶׁלֹּא רָצָה בַּעְלָהּ לְהַשְׁקוֹתָהּ בֵּין שֶׁלֹּא

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רָצְתָה הִיא וּבִין שֶׁבָּא לָהּ עֵד טֻמְאָה אוֹ הוֹדִית אוֹ הָיְתָה מֵאֵלּוּ הַנָּשִׁים שֶׁאֵינָן רְאוּיוֹת לִשְׁתּוֹת אוֹ שֶׁקִּנְאוּ לָהּ בֵּית דִּין. הוֹאִיל וְנֶאֱסְרָה עַל בַּעְלָהּ מִכָּל מָקוֹם הֲרֵי הִיא אֲסוּרָה עַל זֶה שֶׁנִּתְיַחֲדָה עִמּוֹ לְעוֹלָם כְּדֶרֶךְ שֶׁהִיא אֲסוּרָה עַל בַּעְלָהּ. וְאִם עָבַר וּנְשָׂאָהּ מוֹצִיאִין אוֹתָהּ מִתַּחְתָּיו בְּגֵט אֲפִלּוּ הָיוּ לָהּ כַּמָּה בָּנִים מִמֶּנּוּ. מִפִּי הַשְּׁמוּעָה לָמְדוּ כְּשֵׁם שֶׁאֲסוּרָה לַבַּעַל כָּךְ אֲסוּרָה לַבּוֹעֵל:

Whenever a warning was administered to a woman and she entered into privacy [with the man in question], but did not drink the bitter water - whether her husband did not desire to compel her to drink, she did not want to drink, a witness testified that she committed adultery, she was one of the women who are unfit to drink [the bitter water], or the warning was administered by the court [and not by her husband] - since she becomes forbidden to her husband, she also becomes forbidden to the man with whom she entered into privacy just as she is forbidden to her husband. If this other man transgresses and marries her, he is compelled to divorce her even if she has borne him many children. Based on the Oral Tradition our Sages taught: Just as she is forbidden to her husband, she is forbidden to the man with whom she engaged in relations.

Halachah 13

אֲבָל אִם לֹא קָדַם קִנּוּי וּבָאוּ עָלֶיהָ עֵדִים שֶׁנִּסְתְּרָה עִם אִישׁ זֶה וּבָאוּ וּמָצְאוּ דָּבָר מְכֹעָר כְּגוֹן שֶׁנִּכְנְסוּ אַחֲרָיו וּמְצָאוּהָ חוֹגֶרֶת חֲגוֹרָה. אוֹ מָצְאוּ רֹק לְמַעְלָה מִן הַכְּילָה וְכֵיוֹצֵא בָּזֶה. אִם הוֹצִיאָהּ בַּעְלָהּ בְּדָבָר מְכֹעָר כָּזֶה הֲרֵי זוֹ לֹא תִּנָּשֵׂא לַנָּטְעָן אֶלָּא אֲסוּרָה עָלָיו. וְאִם עָבַר וּנְשָׂאָהּ וְהָיוּ לָהּ בָּנִים מִמֶּנּוּ לֹא תֵּצֵא. וְאִם לֹא הָיוּ לָהּ בָּנִים מִמֶּנּוּ תֵּצֵא:

[Different rules apply when,] however, a woman was not warned and witnesses came and testified that she entered into privacy with a man, and then they discovered unsavory behavior: e.g., they entered [her room] after [the man in question did] and saw her tying her belt, they found wet spittle on the bed's canopy, or the like. If her husband divorces her because of this unsavory behavior, she should not marry the man with whom she is suspected [of having relations]; instead, she should be forbidden to him. If she transgresses and marries [this man] and children are born to them, she need not be divorced. If she has not borne [this man] children, he must divorce her.

Halachah 14

בַּמֶּה דְּבָרִים אֲמוּרִים בְּשֶׁרְנָנוּ הָעִיר עָלֶיהָ וְעַל הַנִּטְעָן יוֹם וּמֶחֱצָה אוֹ יוֹתֵר. וְאָמְרוּ פְּלוֹנִי זְנָה עִם פְּלוֹנִית וְלֹא פָּסַק הַקּוֹל. וְהוּא שֶׁלֹּא הָיוּ לָהּ אוֹ לוֹ אוֹיְבִים שֶׁמַּעֲבִירִין אֶת הַקּוֹל. אֲבָל אִם לֹא הָיְתָה שָׁם רִנָּה לְדָבָר זֶה בָּעִיר אוֹ שֶׁפָּסַק הַקּוֹל שֶׁלֹּא מֵחֲמַת יִרְאָה. אִם נִשֵּׂאת לַנִּטְעָן לֹא תֵּצֵא אַף עַל פִּי שֶׁאֵין לָהּ בָּנִים. אֲפִלּוּ בָּא עֵד אֶחָד שֶׁזִּנְּתָה עִמּוֹ לֹא תֵּצֵא:

When does the above apply? When [the inhabitants of] a city gossiped about the man and woman in question for a day and a half or more, saying: "So and so committed adultery

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with so and so," and this rumor did not cease. [Moreover, this applies] only when neither [the man nor the woman in question] have enemies who spread this rumor. If, however, the rumor was not widespread throughout the city, or the rumor ceased for reasons other than fear [different rules apply]. If she marries [the man in question], she need not be divorced although she has not borne him any children. Even when one witness comes and testifies that she committed adultery with him, she need not be divorced.

Halachah 15

מִי שֶׁהוֹצִיאָהּ בַּעְלָהּ בְּעֵדֵי דָּבָר מְכֹעָר וְנִשֵּׂאת לְאַחֵר וְגֵרְשָׁהּ הֲרֵי זוֹ אֲסוּרָה לְהִנָּשֵׂא לַנִּטְעָן שֶׁיָּצָאתָה מִתַּחַת בַּעְלָהּ בְּגִלָּלוֹ. וְאִם נִשֵּׂאת לֹא תֵּצֵא אַף עַל פִּי שֶׁאֵין לָהּ בָּנִים:

If a woman who was divorced by her [first] husband for unsavory behavior marries another man and is later divorced by him, she is forbidden to marry the man because of whom she was divorced by her first husband. If, however, she marries him, he is not compelled to divorce her even though she has not borne him children.

Halachah 16

כָּל אִשָּׁה שֶׁבָּאוּ שְׁנֵי עֵדִים וְהֵעִידוּ שֶׁזִּנְּתָה עִם זֶה כְּשֶׁהָיְתָה תַּחַת בַּעְלָהּ הָרִאשׁוֹן הֲרֵי זוֹ תֵּצֵא מִזֶּה. וְאַף עַל פִּי שֶׁיֵּשׁ לָהּ מִמֶּנּוּ כַּמָּה בָּנִים. וְכָל מָקוֹם שֶׁאָמַרְנוּ תֵּצֵא תֵּצֵא בְּלֹא כְּתֻבָּה:

Whenever two witnesses testify that, while she was married to another man, a woman committed adultery with the man to whom she is presently married, she must be divorced by her present husband even though she has borne him several children. In all the instances where we said that a woman must be divorced, she is not entitled to receive [the money due her by virtue of] her ketubah.

Commentary

The chapter is a map of the sotah ritual's boundaries. The Rambam opens with the procedure's soft edge (1: a woman who confesses is divorced without drinking), then catalogs who is exempt from the waters even if she wants to drink (2–7: the arusah, the shomeret yavam, the minor, the pregnant and nursing woman), anchors each exemption in its verse (3: 'while married' excludes the merely consecrated), and then turns the lens around — from the woman's fitness to the husband's (8–10).

That turn is the chapter's moral architecture. Halachah 8: a husband who has himself engaged in forbidden relations since his majority — the bitter waters do not test his wife. Halachah 9 extends it to forbidden marriages; halachah 10 to marriages the Sages deemed undesirable. The ordeal is not a husband's weapon; it only functions when the accuser is clean. The Rambam has built a symmetry into the ritual: suspicion must be pure to be tested.

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The commentators show their characteristic methods on this chapter. Kessef Mishneh is the source-tracer: 2:1 is pinned to Sotah 20a (פרק היה נוטל), 2:2 to the mishnah at the opening of פרק ארוסה, 2:16 to the laws of ketubah in Hilchot Ishut 24 — every ruling given its Talmudic address. Migdal Oz works the same seam on 2:1 (פרק ארוסה ושומרת יבם, ד"דף כ).

Ohr Sameach is the conceptual analyst, and on 2:16 he is genuinely startled — 'נפלאתי מאד.' A woman proved by two witnesses to have committed adultery with her present husband while married to her first must leave him without ketubah. But in ordinary חייבי עשה the wife keeps her ketubah even without prior knowledge — so why is this sotah-adulteress worse than, say, one who remarries her divorcé? The question is left hanging in the fetched text, but it exposes the chapter's fault line: the sotah laws treat betrayal as a category of their own, harsher than the formal ladder of prohibitions would predict.

The closing movement (12–16) handles the cases where the waters never get drunk: the husband who won't compel, the witness who testifies, the city gossip that won't die (14: rumor persisting a day and a half), and the woman divorced for unsavory behavior who may never marry the man she was rumored with (15–16). When the ritual cannot run, the law still has to dispose of the marriage — the chapter is as much about exits as about ordeals.

Commentary texts: Kessef Mishneh and Migdal Oz on Sotah 2:1, Ohr Sameach on Sotah 2:16 (Sefaria).

SHNAYIM MIKRA · ALIYAH 7

Genesis 11:1-11:32

32 verses

The week's reading closes with humanity's second fall and the quiet genealogy that leads to Abram. The aliyah holds the Tower of Babel (11:1–9) — one language, one plan, one tower — and then the ten generations from Shem to Terach (11:10–26), ending with Terach's family setting out from Ur of the Chaldees and stalling at Haran (11:27–32). Read it twice in Hebrew, once in Onkelos's Aramaic: the shnayim mikra practice lets the translation's choices — what it softens, what it sharpens — teach the verses back to you.

Genesis 11:1 · ×2

וַיְהִי כָל־הָאָרֶץ שָׂפָה אֶחָת וּדְבָרִים אֲחָדִים׃
וַיְהִי כָל־הָאָרֶץ שָׂפָה אֶחָת וּדְבָרִים אֲחָדִים׃
וַהֲוָה כָל אַרְעָא לִישָׁן חָד וּמַמְלַל חָד׃

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Genesis 11:2 · ×2

וַיְהִי בְּנָסְעָם מִקֶּדֶם וַיִּמְצְאוּ בִקְעָה בְּאֶרֶץ שִׁנְעָר וַיֵּשְׁבוּ שָׁם׃
וַיְהִי בְּנָסְעָם מִקֶּדֶם וַיִּמְצְאוּ בִקְעָה בְּאֶרֶץ שִׁנְעָר וַיֵּשְׁבוּ שָׁם׃
וַהֲוָה בְּמִטַּלְהוֹן בְּקַדְמֵיתָא וְאַשְׁכָּחוּ בִּקְעָתָא בְּאַרְעָא דְּבָבֶל וִיתִיבוּ תַּמָּן׃

Genesis 11:3 · ×2

וַיֹּאמְרוּ אִישׁ אֶל־רֵעֵהוּ הָבָה נִלְבְּנָה לְבֵנִים וְנִשְׂרְפָה לִשְׂרֵפָה וַתְּהִי לָהֶם הַלְּבֵנָה לְאָבֶן וְהַחֵמָר הָיָה לָהֶם לַחֹמֶר׃
וַיֹּאמְרוּ אִישׁ אֶל־רֵעֵהוּ הָבָה נִלְבְּנָה לְבֵנִים וְנִשְׂרְפָה לִשְׂרֵפָה וַתְּהִי לָהֶם הַלְּבֵנָה לְאָבֶן וְהַחֵמָר הָיָה לָהֶם לַחֹמֶר׃
וַאֲמָרוּ גְּבַר לְחַבְרֵיהּ הָבוּ נֵרְמֵי לִבְנִין וְנִשְׂרְפִנּוּן בְּנוּרָא (יוֹקַדְתָּא) וַהֲוַת לְהוֹן לִבְנְתָּא לְאַבְנָא וְחֵימָרָא הֲוָה לְהוֹן לְשִׁיעַ׃

Genesis 11:4 · ×2

וַיֹּאמְרוּ הָבָה | נִבְנֶה־לָּנוּ עִיר וּמִגְדָּל וְרֹאשׁוֹ בַּשָּׁמַיִם וְנַעֲשֶׂה־לָּנוּ שֵׁם פֶּן־נָפוּץ עַל־פְּנֵי כָל־הָאָרֶץ׃
וַיֹּאמְרוּ הָבָה | נִבְנֶה־לָּנוּ עִיר וּמִגְדָּל וְרֹאשׁוֹ בַּשָּׁמַיִם וְנַעֲשֶׂה־לָּנוּ שֵׁם פֶּן־נָפוּץ עַל־פְּנֵי כָל־הָאָרֶץ׃
וַאֲמָרוּ הָבוּ נִבְנֵי לָנָא קַרְתָּא וּמַגְדְּלָא וְרִישֵׁיהּ מָטֵי עַד צֵית שְׁמַיָּא וְנַעֲבֵיד לָנָא שׁוּם דֵּילְמָא נִתְבַּדַּר עַל אַפֵּי כָל אַרְעָא׃

Genesis 11:5 · ×2

וַיֵּרֶד יְהוָה לִרְאֹת אֶת־הָעִיר וְאֶת־הַמִּגְדָּל אֲשֶׁר בָּנוּ בְּנֵי הָאָדָם׃
וַיֵּרֶד יְהוָה לִרְאֹת אֶת־הָעִיר וְאֶת־הַמִּגְדָּל אֲשֶׁר בָּנוּ בְּנֵי הָאָדָם׃
וְאִתְגְּלִי יְיָ לְאִתְפְּרָעָא עַל עוֹבָדֵי קַרְתָּא וּמַגְדְּלָא דִּי בְנוֹ בְּנֵי אֱנָשָׁא׃

Genesis 11:6 · ×2

וַיֹּאמֶר יְהוָה הֵן עַם אֶחָד וְשָׂפָה אַחַת לְכֻלָּם וְזֶה הַחִלָּם לַעֲשׂוֹת וְעַתָּה לֹא־יִבָּצֵר מֵהֶם כֹּל אֲשֶׁר יָזְמוּ לַעֲשׂוֹת׃
וַיֹּאמֶר יְהוָה הֵן עַם אֶחָד וְשָׂפָה אַחַת לְכֻלָּם וְזֶה הַחִלָּם לַעֲשׂוֹת וְעַתָּה לֹא־יִבָּצֵר מֵהֶם כֹּל אֲשֶׁר יָזְמוּ לַעֲשׂוֹת׃
וַאֲמַר יְיָ הָא עַמָּא חַד וְלִישָׁן חַד לְכֻלְּהוֹן וְדֵין דְּשָׁרִיו לְמֶעְבַּד וּכְעַן לָא יִתְמְנַע מִנְּהוֹן כֹּל דְּחַשִׁיבוּ לְמֶעְבַּד׃

Genesis 11:7 · ×2

הָבָה נָרְדָה וְנָבְלָה שָׁם שְׂפָתָם אֲשֶׁר לֹא יִשְׁמְעוּ אִישׁ שְׂפַת רֵעֵהוּ׃
הָבָה נָרְדָה וְנָבְלָה שָׁם שְׂפָתָם אֲשֶׁר לֹא יִשְׁמְעוּ אִישׁ שְׂפַת רֵעֵהוּ׃
הָבוּ נִתְגְּלֵי וּנְבַלְבֵּל תַּמָּן לִישָׁנְהוֹן דְּלָא יִשְׁמְעוּן אֱנַשׁ (גְּבַר) לִישַׁן חַבְרֵיהּ׃

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Genesis 11:8 · ×2

וַיָּפֶץ יְהוָה אֹתָם מִשָּׁם עַל־פְּנֵי כָל־הָאָרֶץ וַיַּחְדְּלוּ לִבְנֹת הָעִיר׃
וַיָּפֶץ יְהוָה אֹתָם מִשָּׁם עַל־פְּנֵי כָל־הָאָרֶץ וַיַּחְדְּלוּ לִבְנֹת הָעִיר׃
וּבַדַּר יְיָ יָתְהוֹן מִתַּמָּן עַל אַפֵּי כָל אַרְעָא וּמְנָעוּ לְמִבְנֵי (נ"י וְאִתְמְנָעוּ מִלְּמִבְנֵי) קַרְתָּא׃

Genesis 11:9 · ×2

עַל־כֵּן קָרָא שְׁמָהּ בָּבֶל כִּי־שָׁם בָּלַל יְהוָה שְׂפַת כָּל־הָאָרֶץ וּמִשָּׁם הֱפִיצָם יְהוָה עַל־פְּנֵי כָל־הָאָרֶץ׃
עַל־כֵּן קָרָא שְׁמָהּ בָּבֶל כִּי־שָׁם בָּלַל יְהוָה שְׂפַת כָּל־הָאָרֶץ וּמִשָּׁם הֱפִיצָם יְהוָה עַל־פְּנֵי כָל־הָאָרֶץ׃
עַל כֵּן קְרָא שְׁמַהּ בָּבֶל אֲרֵי תַמָּן בַּלְבֵּל יְיָ לִישַׁן כָּל אַרְעָא וּמִתַּמָּן בַּדְּרִנּוּן יְיָ עַל אַפֵּי כָל אַרְעָא׃

שנה ויולד שנין ואוליד

Genesis 11:10 · ×2

אֵלֶּה תּוֹלְדֹת שֵׁם שֵׁם בֶּן־מְאַת שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד אֶת־אַרְפַּכְשַׁד שְׁנָתַיִם אַחַר הַמַּבּוּל׃
אֵלֶּה תּוֹלְדֹת שֵׁם שֵׁם בֶּן־מְאַת שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד אֶת־אַרְפַּכְשַׁד שְׁנָתַיִם אַחַר הַמַּבּוּל׃
אִלֵּין תּוּלְדַת שֵׁם שֵׁם בַּר מְאָה שְׁנִין וְאוֹלִיד יָת אַרְפַּכְשַׁד תַּרְתֵּין שְׁנִין בָּתַר טוֹפָנָא׃

הולידו

Genesis 11:11 · ×2

וַיְחִי־שֵׁם אַחֲרֵי הוֹלִידוֹ אֶת־אַרְפַּכְשַׁד חֲמֵשׁ מֵאוֹת שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד בָּנִים וּבָנוֹת׃
וַיְחִי־שֵׁם אַחֲרֵי הוֹלִידוֹ אֶת־אַרְפַּכְשַׁד חֲמֵשׁ מֵאוֹת שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד בָּנִים וּבָנוֹת׃
וְחָיָא שֵׁם בָּתַר דְּאוֹלִיד יָת אַרְפַּכְשַׁד חֲמֵשׁ מְאָה שְׁנִין וְאוֹלִיד בְּנִין וּבְנָן׃

Genesis 11:12 · ×2

וְאַרְפַּכְשַׁד חַי חָמֵשׁ וּשְׁלֹשִׁים שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד אֶת־שָׁלַח׃
וְאַרְפַּכְשַׁד חַי חָמֵשׁ וּשְׁלֹשִׁים שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד אֶת־שָׁלַח׃
וְאַרְפַּכְשַׁד חָיָא תְּלָתִין וַחֲמֵשׁ שְׁנִין וְאוֹלִיד יָת שָׁלַח׃

Genesis 11:13 · ×2

וַיְחִי אַרְפַּכְשַׁד אַחֲרֵי הוֹלִידוֹ אֶת־שֶׁלַח שָׁלֹשׁ שָׁנִים וְאַרְבַּע מֵאוֹת שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד בָּנִים וּבָנוֹת׃
וַיְחִי אַרְפַּכְשַׁד אַחֲרֵי הוֹלִידוֹ אֶת־שֶׁלַח שָׁלֹשׁ שָׁנִים וְאַרְבַּע מֵאוֹת שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד בָּנִים וּבָנוֹת׃
וְחָיָא אַרְפַּכְשַׁד בָּתַר דְּאוֹלִיד יָת שֶׁלַח אַרְבַּע מְאָה וּתְלָת שְׁנִין וְאוֹלִיד בְּנִין וּבְנָן׃

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Genesis 11:14 · ×2

וְשֶׁלַח חַי שְׁלֹשִׁים שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד אֶת־עֵבֶר׃
וְשֶׁלַח חַי שְׁלֹשִׁים שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד אֶת־עֵבֶר׃
וְשֶׁלַח חֲיָא תְּלָתִין שְׁנִין וְאוֹלִיד יָת עֵבֶר׃

Genesis 11:15 · ×2

וַיְחִי־שֶׁלַח אַחֲרֵי הוֹלִידוֹ אֶת־עֵבֶר שָׁלֹשׁ שָׁנִים וְאַרְבַּע מֵאוֹת שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד בָּנִים וּבָנוֹת׃
וַיְחִי־שֶׁלַח אַחֲרֵי הוֹלִידוֹ אֶת־עֵבֶר שָׁלֹשׁ שָׁנִים וְאַרְבַּע מֵאוֹת שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד בָּנִים וּבָנוֹת׃
וַחֲיָא שֶׁלַח בָּתַר דְּאוֹלִיד יָת עֵבֶר אַרְבַּע מְאָה וּתְלָת שְׁנִין וְאוֹלִיד בְּנִין וּבְנָן׃

Genesis 11:16 · ×2

וַיְחִי־עֵבֶר אַרְבַּע וּשְׁלֹשִׁים שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד אֶת־פָּלֶג׃
וַיְחִי־עֵבֶר אַרְבַּע וּשְׁלֹשִׁים שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד אֶת־פָּלֶג׃
וַחֲיָא עֵבֶר תְּלָתִין וְאַרְבַּע שְׁנִין וְאוֹלִיד יָת פָּלֶג׃

Genesis 11:17 · ×2

וַיְחִי־עֵבֶר אַחֲרֵי הוֹלִידוֹ אֶת־פֶּלֶג שְׁלֹשִׁים שָׁנָה וְאַרְבַּע מֵאוֹת שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד בָּנִים וּבָנוֹת׃
וַיְחִי־עֵבֶר אַחֲרֵי הוֹלִידוֹ אֶת־פֶּלֶג שְׁלֹשִׁים שָׁנָה וְאַרְבַּע מֵאוֹת שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד בָּנִים וּבָנוֹת׃
וַחֲיָא עֵבֶר בָּתַר דְּאוֹלִיד יָת פָּלֶג אַרְבַּע מְאָה וּתְלָתִין שְׁנִין וְאוֹלִיד בְּנִין וּבְנָן׃

Genesis 11:18 · ×2

וַיְחִי־פֶלֶג שְׁלֹשִׁים שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד אֶת־רְעוּ׃
וַיְחִי־פֶלֶג שְׁלֹשִׁים שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד אֶת־רְעוּ׃
וַחֲיָא פָּלֶג תְּלָתִין שְׁנִין וְאוֹלִיד יָת רְעוּ׃

Genesis 11:19 · ×2

וַיְחִי־פֶלֶג אַחֲרֵי הוֹלִידוֹ אֶת־רְעוּ תֵּשַׁע שָׁנִים וּמָאתַיִם שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד בָּנִים וּבָנוֹת׃
וַיְחִי־פֶלֶג אַחֲרֵי הוֹלִידוֹ אֶת־רְעוּ תֵּשַׁע שָׁנִים וּמָאתַיִם שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד בָּנִים וּבָנוֹת׃
וַחֲיָא פָּלֶג בָּתַר דְּאוֹלִיד יָת רְעוּ מָאתָן וּתְשַׁע שְׁנִין וְאוֹלִיד בְּנִין וּבְנָן׃

Genesis 11:20 · ×2

וַיְחִי רְעוּ שְׁתַּיִם וּשְׁלֹשִׁים שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד אֶת־שְׂרוּג׃
וַיְחִי רְעוּ שְׁתַּיִם וּשְׁלֹשִׁים שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד אֶת־שְׂרוּג׃
וַחֲיָא רְעוּ תְּלָתִין וְתַרְתֵּין שְׁנִין וְאוֹלִיד יָת שְׂרוּג׃

Genesis 11:21 · ×2

וַיְחִי רְעוּ אַחֲרֵי הוֹלִידוֹ אֶת־שְׂרוּג שֶׁבַע שָׁנִים וּמָאתַיִם שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד בָּנִים וּבָנוֹת׃
וַיְחִי רְעוּ אַחֲרֵי הוֹלִידוֹ אֶת־שְׂרוּג שֶׁבַע שָׁנִים וּמָאתַיִם שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד בָּנִים וּבָנוֹת׃
וַחֲיָא רְעוּ בָּתַר דְּאוֹלִיד יָת שְׂרוּג מָאתָן וּשְׁבַע שְׁנִין וְאוֹלִיד בְּנִין וּבְנָן׃

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Genesis 11:22 · ×2

וַיְחִי שְׂרוּג שְׁלֹשִׁים שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד אֶת־נָחוֹר׃
וַיְחִי שְׂרוּג שְׁלֹשִׁים שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד אֶת־נָחוֹר׃
וַחֲיָא שְׂרוּג תְּלָתִין שְׁנִין וְאוֹלִיד יָת נָחוֹר׃

Genesis 11:23 · ×2

וַיְחִי שְׂרוּג אַחֲרֵי הוֹלִידוֹ אֶת־נָחוֹר מָאתַיִם שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד בָּנִים וּבָנוֹת׃
וַיְחִי שְׂרוּג אַחֲרֵי הוֹלִידוֹ אֶת־נָחוֹר מָאתַיִם שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד בָּנִים וּבָנוֹת׃
וַחֲיָא שְׂרוּג בָּתַר דְּאוֹלִיד יָת נָחוֹר מָאתָן שְׁנִין וְאוֹלִיד בְּנִין וּבְנָן׃

Genesis 11:24 · ×2

וַיְחִי נָחוֹר תֵּשַׁע וְעֶשְׂרִים שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד אֶת־תָּרַח׃
וַיְחִי נָחוֹר תֵּשַׁע וְעֶשְׂרִים שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד אֶת־תָּרַח׃
וַחֲיָא נָחוֹר עֶשְׂרִין וּתְשַׁע שְׁנִין וְאוֹלִיד יָת תָּרַח׃

Genesis 11:25 · ×2

וַיְחִי נָחוֹר אַחֲרֵי הוֹלִידוֹ אֶת־תֶּרַח תְּשַׁע־עֶשְׂרֵה שָׁנָה וּמְאַת שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד בָּנִים וּבָנוֹת׃
וַיְחִי נָחוֹר אַחֲרֵי הוֹלִידוֹ אֶת־תֶּרַח תְּשַׁע־עֶשְׂרֵה שָׁנָה וּמְאַת שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד בָּנִים וּבָנוֹת׃
וַחֲיָא נָחוֹר בָּתַר דְּאוֹלִיד יָת תֶּרַח מְאָה וּתְשַׁע עֲשַׂר שְׁנִין וְאוֹלִיד בְּנִין וּבְנָן׃

Genesis 11:26 · ×2

וַיְחִי־תֶרַח שִׁבְעִים שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד אֶת־אַבְרָם אֶת־נָחוֹר וְאֶת־הָרָן׃
וַיְחִי־תֶרַח שִׁבְעִים שָׁנָה וַיּוֹלֶד אֶת־אַבְרָם אֶת־נָחוֹר וְאֶת־הָרָן׃
וַחֲיָא תֶרַח שִׁבְעִין שְׁנִין וְאוֹלִיד יָת אַבְרָם יָת נָחוֹר וְיָת הָרָן׃

Genesis 11:27 · ×2

וְאֵלֶּה תּוֹלְדֹת תֶּרַח תֶּרַח הוֹלִיד אֶת־אַבְרָם אֶת־נָחוֹר וְאֶת־הָרָן וְהָרָן הוֹלִיד אֶת־לוֹט׃
וְאֵלֶּה תּוֹלְדֹת תֶּרַח תֶּרַח הוֹלִיד אֶת־אַבְרָם אֶת־נָחוֹר וְאֶת־הָרָן וְהָרָן הוֹלִיד אֶת־לוֹט׃
וְאִלֵּין תּוֹלְדַת תֶּרַח תֶּרַח אוֹלִיד יָת אַבְרָם יָת נָחוֹר וְיָת הָרָן וְהָרָן אוֹלִיד יָת לוֹט׃

Genesis 11:28 · ×2

וַיָּמָת הָרָן עַל־פְּנֵי תֶּרַח אָבִיו בְּאֶרֶץ מוֹלַדְתּוֹ בְּאוּר כַּשְׂדִּים׃
וַיָּמָת הָרָן עַל־פְּנֵי תֶּרַח אָבִיו בְּאֶרֶץ מוֹלַדְתּוֹ בְּאוּר כַּשְׂדִּים׃
וּמִית הָרָן עַל אַפֵּי תֶּרַח אֲבוּהִי בְּאַרְעָא דְיַלְּדוּתֵיהּ בְּאוּרָא דְכַסְדָּאֵי׃

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Genesis 11:29 · ×2

וַיִּקַּח אַבְרָם וְנָחוֹר לָהֶם נָשִׁים שֵׁם אֵשֶׁת־אַבְרָם שָׂרָי וְשֵׁם אֵשֶׁת־נָחוֹר מִלְכָּה בַּת־הָרָן אֲבִי־מִלְכָּה וַאֲבִי יִסְכָּה׃

וַיִּקַּח אַבְרָם וְנָחוֹר לָהֶם נָשִׁים שֵׁם אֵשֶׁת־אַבְרָם שָׂרָי וְשֵׁם אֵשֶׁת־נָחוֹר מִלְכָּה בַּת־הָרָן אֲבִי־מִלְכָּה וַאֲבִי יִסְכָּה׃

וּנְסִיב אַבְרָם וְנָחוֹר לְהוֹן נְשִׁין שׁוּם אִתַּת אַבְרָם שָׂרִי וְשׁוּם אִתַּת נָחוֹר מִלְכָּה בַּת הָרָן אֲבוּהָא דְמִלְכָּה וַאֲבוּהָא דְיִסְכָּה׃

Genesis 11:30 · ×2

וַתְּהִי שָׂרַי עֲקָרָה אֵין לָהּ וָלָד׃

וַתְּהִי שָׂרַי עֲקָרָה אֵין לָהּ וָלָד׃

וַהֲוַת שָׂרַי עֲקָרָה לֵית לַהּ וְלָד׃

Genesis 11:31 · ×2

וַיִּקַּח תֶּרַח אֶת־אַבְרָם בְּנוֹ וְאֶת־לוֹט בֶּן־הָרָן בֶּן־בְּנוֹ וְאֵת שָׂרַי כַּלָּתוֹ אֵשֶׁת אַבְרָם בְּנוֹ וַיֵּצְאוּ אִתָּם מֵאוּר כַּשְׂדִּים לָלֶכֶת אַרְצָה כְּנַעַן וַיָּבֹאוּ עַד־חָרָן וַיֵּשְׁבוּ שָׁם׃

וַיִּקַּח תֶּרַח אֶת־אַבְרָם בְּנוֹ וְאֶת־לוֹט בֶּן־הָרָן בֶּן־בְּנוֹ וְאֵת שָׂרַי כַּלָּתוֹ אֵשֶׁת אַבְרָם בְּנוֹ וַיֵּצְאוּ אִתָּם מֵאוּר כַּשְׂדִּים לָלֶכֶת אַרְצָה כְּנַעַן וַיָּבֹאוּ עַד־חָרָן וַיֵּשְׁבוּ שָׁם׃

וּדְבַר תֶּרַח יָת אַבְרָם בְּרֵיהּ וְיָת לוֹט בַּר הָרָן בַּר בְּרֵיהּ וְיָת שָׂרַי כַּלְתֵּיהּ אִתַּת אַבְרָם בְּרֵיהּ וּנְפָקוּ עִמְּהוֹן מֵאוּרָא דְכַסְדָּאֵי לְמֵיזַל לְאַרְעָא דִכְנָעַן וַאֲתוֹ עַד חָרָן וִיתִיבוּ תַּמָּן׃

Genesis 11:32 · ×2

וַיִּהְיוּ יְמֵי־תֶרַח חָמֵשׁ שָׁנִים וּמָאתַיִם שָׁנָה וַיָּמָת תֶּרַח בְּחָרָן׃

וַיִּהְיוּ יְמֵי־תֶרַח חָמֵשׁ שָׁנִים וּמָאתַיִם שָׁנָה וַיָּמָת תֶּרַח בְּחָרָן׃

וַהֲווֹ יוֹמֵי תֶרַח מָאתָן וְחַמֵּשׁ שְׁנִין וּמִית תֶּרַח בְּחָרָן׃

Commentary quick hits

Shadal · Gen 11:1

Against Vitringa and Clericus, who read 'one language' as mere agreement of counsel: verse 7's 'they shall not understand one another's speech' proves it was literally one tongue. And שפה is the language system itself — roots, conjugations, tenses — while דברים is the use of those roots for meanings.

Ibn Ezra · Gen 11:4

הבה is 'give/prepare' (root יהב, cf. Psalms 55:23), in the plural because it is addressed to many; and 'its top in heaven' is hyperbole of the same kind as 'cities great and fortified in heaven' (Deuteronomy 1:28).

shi: Sefaria; sources via Sefaria links. Lexicons: Klein, Jastrow, BDB via Sefaria; Maagarim via the Historical Dictionary Project of the Academy of the Hebrew Language. In the words in

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Em LaMikra · Gen 11:5

The tower the builders raised is still identifiable: the Arabs call it Birs Nimrud, likely for Nimrod the chief builder — and travelers (he cites Keppel's Travels in Babylonia) report the bricks still blackened from the fire that burned in them.

HaKtav VeHaKabalah · Gen 11:7

הבה נרדה cannot be an interjection rousing to action — God needs no rousing. And the building itself was no sin; it was the cause from which great sins would follow, though their wickedness did not yet merit punishment.

Netinah LaGer · Gen 11:1

ודברים אחדים — 'one speech': small and great alike, fool and wise alike. The unity of Babel cut across every social stratum, which is what made it formidable.

Onkelos: translation notes

Gen 11:1

לישן חד וממלל חד שפה אחת ודברים אחדים

Onkelos renders שפה (literally 'lip') as לישן ('tongue, language') — his standard lexical move wherever שפה means speech — and דברים as ממלל ('utterance'). The doubling is preserved: one tongue, one speech.

Gen 11:2

בארעא דבבל ...במטלהון בקדמיתא בארץ שנער ...בנסעם מקדם

Two interpretive calls: מקדם is read temporally ('at first') rather than 'from the east,' and ארץ שנער is identified outright as Babylonia (ארעא דבבל) — Onkelos the geographer, fixing the map for his readers.

Gen 11:3

ונשרפנון בנורא ונשרפה לשרפה

The Hebrew's elegant infinitive-absolute construction ('burn them a burning') becomes plain Aramaic process: 'and we will burn them in fire.' Onkelos routinely unpacks Hebrew paronomasia into explicit procedure.

Gen 11:4

ורישיה מטי עד צית שמיא וראשו בשמים

The hyperbole is softened: not 'its top in heaven' but 'its top reaches to the edge of heaven.' Onkelos reins in the builders' boast even as he translates it.

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Gen 11:5

ואתגלי יי לאתפרעא על עובדי קרתא וירד יהוה לראות

The signature anti-anthropomorphism: no 'descending to see.' Instead 'the Lord was revealed, to punish the deeds of the city.' Divine investigation becomes divine manifestation — and judgment.

Gen 11:7

הבו נתגלי ונבלבל הבה נרדה ונבלה

The same move in the plural cohortative: not 'let us go down' but 'let us be revealed.' God's 'descent' is consistently translated as revelation, never locomotion.

Gen 11:9

בלבל ...בבל בלל ...בבל

The etymological wordplay survives translation: Babel/balal becomes בלבל/בבל in Aramaic, preserving the verse's own explanation of the name.

Gen 11:10

תרתין שנין בתר טופנא שנתים אחר המבול

Onkelos's fixed term for the Flood is טופנא, never מבולא — used consistently from Genesis 6 onward. A reminder that his translation choices are systematic, not ad hoc.

Gen 11:31

ודבר תרח ויקח תרח

'Terach took' becomes 'Terach led' (ודבר). Where the Hebrew has the family patriarch merely gathering his household, Onkelos gives him the verb of leadership — the migration already has a leader.

RASHI

Rashi on the day's aliyah

26 comments

All 26 of Rashi's comments on Genesis 11:1–32, in full — his Hebrew with the classic English rendering, from the one-language debate through Terach's death in Haran.

שפה אחת.
לְשׁוֹן הַקֹּדֶשׁ:

שפה אחת *ONE LANGUAGE — The Holy Tongue (Hebrew) (Midrash Tanchuma, Noach 19).*

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ודברים אחדים.

בָּאוּ בְעֵצָה אַחַת וְאָמְרוּ לֹא כָּל הֵימֶנּוּ שֶׁיִּבֹּר לוֹ אֶת הָעֶלְיוֹנִים,

ודברים אחדים *AND ONE SPEECH — They came with one plan, saying: "He has no right to select the heavenly regions exclusively for Himself;*

let us ascend to the skies and make war upon Him".

Another explanation (of דברים אחדים *which is taken to mean "words referring to "One"):*

נַעֲלֶה לָרָקִיעַ וְנַעֲשֶׂה עִמּוֹ מִלְחָמָה. דָּבָר אֶחָד עַל יְחִידוּ שֶׁל עוֹלָם. דִּבֵּר אֶחָד וּדְבָרִים אֲחָדִים

words regarding the Sole Being (God) in the Universe.

Another explanation of ודברים אחדים *is:*

they spoke דברים חדים *"sharp" words;*

אָמְרוּ אַחַת לְאֶלֶף ותרנ"ו שָׁנִים הָרָקִיעַ מִתְמוֹטֵט כְּשֵׁם שֶׁעָשָׂה בִּימֵי הַמַּבּוּל, בֹּאוּ וְנַעֲשֶׂה לוֹ סְמִיכוֹת (ב"ר):

they said, "Once in every one thousand six hundred and fifty six years (the period that elapsed from the Creation to the Flood) there is a heaven-shaking, just as there was in the days of the Flood.

Come.

then, and let us make supports for it" (Genesis Rabbah 38:6).

בנסעם מקדם.

שֶׁהָיוּ יוֹשְׁבִים שָׁם, כְּדִכְתִיב לְמַעְלָה וַיְהִי מוֹשָׁבָם וְגו' הַר הַקֶּדֶם וְנָסְעוּ מִשָּׁם לָתוּר לָהֶם מָקוֹם לְהַחֲזִיק אֶת כֻּלָּם וְלֹא מָצְאוּ אֶלָּא שִׁנְעָר:

בנסעם מקדם *AS THEY JOURNEYED FROM THE EAST where they were then dwelling, as it is written above, (Genesis 10:30) "And their dwelling place was ... the mountain of the East".*

From there they journeyed to search out for themselves a place that would accommodate them all, but they found none except Shinar (Genesis Rabbah 38:7).

איש אל רעהו.

אֻמָּה לְאֻמָּה, מִצְרַיִם לְכוּשׁ, וְכוּשׁ לְפוּט וּפוּט לִכְנַעַן:

איש אל רעהו *ONE TO ANOTHER — One nation to the other:*

Mizraim to Cush, Cush to Put.

and Put to Canaan (Genesis Rabbah 38:6).

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הבה.
הַזְמִינוּ עַצְמְכֶם. כָּל הָבָה לְשׁוֹן הַזְמָנָה הוּא,

הבה *means, "Prepare yourselves".*

Wherever the word הבה *(come) occurs it has the meaning of "prepare", meaning that they should get themselves ready and unite for some work or plan or burden (undertaking). "Come, get ready":*

שֶׁמְּכִינִים עַצְמָן וּמִתְחַבְּרִים לְמְלָאכָה אוֹ לְעֵצָה אוֹ לְמַשָּׂא. הָבָה הַזְמִינוּ, אפר"לייר בלע"ז:

in old French appareiller;

English to prepare.

לבנים.
שֶׁאֵין אֲבָנִים בְּבָבֶל, שֶׁהִיא בִּקְעָה:

לבנים *BRICKS — For there is no stone in Babel which is a plain.*

ונשרפה לשרפה.
כָּךְ עוֹשִׂין הַלְּבֵנִים שֶׁקּוֹרִין טוויל"ש בל', שׂוֹרְפִים אוֹתָן בְּכִבְשָׁן:

ונשרפה לשרפה *AND BURN THEM THOROUGHLY — This is how bricks, which in old French are called Tuiles, English tiles, are made:*

they fire them in a furnace.

לחמר.
לְטוּחַ הַקִּיר:

לחמר *FOR MORTAR to plaster the walls.*

פן נפוץ.
שֶׁלֹּא יְבִיא עָלֵינוּ שׁוּם מַכָּה לְהָפִיצֵנוּ מִכָּאן:

פן נפוץ *LEST WE BE SCATTERED ABROAD — That He shall not be able by bringing some plague upon us, to scatter us from here.*

וירד ה' לראות.
לֹא הֻצְרַךְ לְכָךְ, אֶלָּא בָּא לְלַמֵּד לְדַיָּנִים שֶׁלֹּא יַרְשִׁיעוּ הַנִּדּוֹן עַד שֶׁיִּרְאוּ וְיָבִינוּ, מִדְרַשׁ רַבִּי תַּנְחוּמָא:

וירד ה לראות' *AND THE LORD CAME DOWN TO SEE — He really did not need to do this, but Scripture intends to teach the judges that they should not proclaim a defendant guilty before they have seen the case and thoroughly understand the matter in question.*

This is to be found in Midrash of R. Tanchuma.

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בני האדם.

אֶלָּא בְּנֵי מִי? שֶׁמָּא בְּנֵי חֲמוֹרִים וּגְמַלִּים?

בני האדם *THE CHILDREN OF MAN (ADAM) — But whose children could they have been (except the children of man, i.e.*

אֶלָּא בְּנֵי אָדָם הָרִאשׁוֹן שֶׁכָּפָה אֶת הַטּוֹבָה וְאָמַר הָאִשָּׁה אֲשֶׁר נָתַתָּ עִמָּדִי,

human beings) — perhaps the children of donkeys or camels?

אַף אֵלּוּ כָּפוּ בַּטּוֹבָה לִמְרֹד בְּמִי שֶׁהִשְׁפִּיעָם טוֹבָה, וּמִלְּטָם מִן הַמַּבּוּל:

But it means the children of Adam Harishon who proved himself ungrateful when he said, (Genesis 3:12) "The woman whom Thou gavest to be with me, [she gave me of the tree etc.]".

These people, also, were ungrateful, rebelling against the One who had showered kindness upon them and had rescued them from the Flood (Genesis Rabbah 38:9).

הן עם אחד.

כָּל טוֹבָה זוֹ יֵשׁ עִמָּהֶן, שֶׁעַם אֶחָד הֵם,

וְשָׂפָה אַחַת לְכֻלָּן וְדָבָר זֶה הֵחֵלּוּ לַעֲשׂוֹת:

הן עם אחד *BEHOLD, THEY ARE ONE PEOPLE — They possess all the advantage of being one people and of having one language common to all of them, and this is what they begin to do!*

החלם.

כְּמוֹ אָמְרָם, עֲשׂוֹתָם לְהַתְחִיל הֵם לַעֲשׂוֹת:

החלם *is infinitive, like* אמרם *"their speaking".* עשותם *"their doing" (i.e. "they speak", "they do") — so here: "they begin to do") (Genesis Rabbah 38:9).*

לא יבצר מהם וגו' לעשות.

בִּתְמִיהָ. יִבָּצֵר לְשׁוֹן מְנִיעָה, כְּתַרְגּוּמוֹ;

לעשות 'לא יבצר מהם וגו *This is a question (although the* ה *which introduces an interrogative sentence is absent):*

SHALL THEY NOT BE RESTRAINED FROM DOING WHAT THEY IMAGINE TO DO?

וְדוֹמֶה לוֹ יִבְצֹר רוּחַ נְגִידִים (תה' ע"ו):

The word יבצר *means "restraining", as the Targum understands it;*

a similar instance is, (Psalms 76:13) "He restrains (יבצור) the spirit of princes".

הבה נרדה.

בְּבֵית דִּינוֹ נִמְלַךְ מֵעֲנָוְתָנוּתוֹ יְתֵרָה:

הבה נרדה *COME, LET US GO DOWN — He took counsel with His Judicial Court because of His exceeding meekness (Sanhedrin 38b)*

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הבה.

מִדָּה כְּנֶגֶד מִדָּה הֵם אָמְרוּ הָבָה נִבְנֶה,

הבה *COME — measure for measure:*

וְהוּא כְּנֶגְדָּם מָדַד וְאָמַר הָבָה נֵרְדָה:

they had said "Come, let us build";

He meted out to them correspondingly saying. "Come let us go down" (Midrash Tanchuma, Noach 18)

ונבלה.

וּנְבַלְבֵּל; נו"ן מְשַׁמֶּשׁ בִּלְשׁוֹן רַבִּים, וְהֵ"א אַחֲרוֹנָה יְתֵרָה, כְּהֵ"א שֶׁל נֵרְדָה:

ונבלה *means AND LET US CONFOUND The* נ *is the plural prefix, and the* ה *at the end is additional to the root as the* ה *in* ונרדה.

לא ישמעו.

זֶה שׁוֹאֵל לְבֵנָה וְזֶה מֵבִיא טִיט, וְזֶה עוֹמֵד עָלָיו וּפוֹצֵעַ אֶת מֹחוֹ:

ולא ישמעו *— THEY MAY NOT UNDERSTAND — One asks for a brick and the other brings him lime:*

the former therefore attacks him and splits open his brains.

ויפץ ה' אתם משם.

בָּעוֹלָם הַזֶּה; מַה שֶּׁאָמְרוּ פֶּן נָפוּץ, נִתְקַיֵּם עֲלֵיהֶם,

ויפץ ה' אתם משם *SO THE LORD SCATTERED THEM ABROAD FROM THENCE—In this world (Sanhedrin 107b).*

What they had said.

הוּא שֶׁאָמַר שְׁלֹמֹה מְגוֹרַת רָשָׁע הִיא תְּבוֹאֶנּוּ (משלי י'):

(Genesis 11:4) "lest we be scattered abroad" really happened to them.

This is what Solomon said, (Proverbs 10:24) "What the wicked fears will come upon him" (Midrash Tanchuma, Noach 18).

shi: Sefaria; sources via Sefaria links. Lexicons: Klein, Jastrow, BDB via Sefaria; Maagarim via the Historical Dictionary Project of the Academy of the Hebrew Language. In the words in

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ומשם הפיצם.

לְמֵד שֶׁאֵין לָהֶם חֵלֶק לָעוֹלָם הַבָּא; וְכִי אֵיזוֹ קָשָׁה,

ומשם הפיצם *AND FROM THENCE DID THE LORD SCATTER THEM —This teaches that they have no portion in the world to come (Sanhedrin 107b).*

שֶׁל דּוֹר הַמַּבּוּל אוֹ שֶׁל דּוֹר הַפַּלָּגָה?

Which sin was greater:

אֵלּוּ לֹא פָשְׁטוּ יָד בָּעֵקֶר וְאֵלּוּ פָּשְׁטוּ יָד בָּעֵקֶר לְהִלָּחֵם בּוֹ,

that of the generation of the Flood or that of the generation of the Dispersion?

וְאֵלּוּ נִשְׁטְפוּ וְאֵלּוּ לֹא נֶאֱבְדוּ מִן הָעוֹלָם?

The former did not stretch forth their hands against God;

אֶלָּא שֶׁדּוֹר הַמַּבּוּל הָיוּ גַּזְלָנִים וְהָיְתָה מְרִיבָה בֵּינֵיהֶם, לְכָךְ נֶאֱבְדוּ;

the latter did stretch forth their hands against God to war against him (surely, then, the sin of the generation of the Dispersion was greater) and yet the former (the generation of the Flood) were drowned and these did not perish from the world!

וְאֵלּוּ הָיוּ נוֹהֲגִים אַהֲבָה וְרֵעוּת בֵּינֵיהֶם, שֶׁנֶּ' שָׂפָה אֶחָת וּדְבָרִים אֲחָדִים,

But the reason is that the generation of the Flood were violent robbers and there was strife among them, and therefore they were destroyed;

לְמַדְתְּ שֶׁשָּׂנְאוּי הַמַּחֲלֹקֶת וְגָדוֹל הַשָּׁלוֹם:

but these conducted themselves in love and friendship, as it is said, "They were one people and had one language". — You may learn from this how hateful to God is strife and how great is peace (Genesis Rabbah 38:6).

שם בן מאת שנה.

כְּשֶׁהוֹלִיד אֶת אַרְפַּכְשָׁד שְׁנָתַיִם אַחַר הַמַּבּוּל:

שם בן מאת שנה *SHEM WAS A HUNDRED YEARS OLD when he begat Arpachshad two years after the Flood.*

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על פני תרח אביו.

בְּחַיֵּי אָבִיו. וּמִדְרַשׁ אַגָּדָה אוֹמֵר שֶׁעַל יְדֵי אָבִיו מֵת;

על פני תרח אביו *IN THE PRESENCE OF HIS FATHER TERAH — meaning during his father's lifetime (Genesis Rabbah 38:13).*

The Midrashic explanation is that he died through his father.

שֶׁקִּבֵּל תֶּרַח עַל אַבְרָם בְּנוֹ לִפְנֵי נִמְרוֹד עַל שֶׁכִּתֵּת אֶת צְלָמָיו, וְהִשְׁלִיכוֹ לְכִבְשַׁן הָאֵשׁ,

For Terah accused his son Abram before Nimrod of having smashed his idols to pieces, and he cast him into a fiery furnace.

Haran waited and said to himself, "If Abram proves triumphant I will be on his side;

if Nimrod wins I shall be on his".

וְהָרָן יוֹשֵׁב וְאוֹמֵר בְּלִבּוֹ אִם אַבְרָם נוֹצֵחַ אֲנִי מִשֶּׁלּוֹ, וְאִם נִמְרוֹד נוֹצֵחַ אֲנִי מִשֶּׁלּוֹ; וּכְשֶׁנִּצַּל אַבְרָם, אָמְרוּ לוֹ לְהָרָן מִשֶּׁל מִי אַתָּה? אָמַר לָהֶם הָרָן מִשֶּׁל אַבְרָם אֲנִי, הִשְׁלִיכוּהוּ לְכִבְשַׁן הָאֵשׁ וְנִשְׂרַף, וְזֶהוּ אוּר כַּשְׂדִּים (ב"ר). וּמְנַחֵם פֵּרֵשׁ אוּר בְּקֵעָה; וְכֵן בָּאֳרִים כַּבְּדוּ ה' (ישעיה כ"ד),

When Abram was saved they said to Haran, "Whose side are you on?" Haran replied, "I am on Abram's side".

They therefore cast him into the fiery furnace and he was burnt to death.

וְכֵן מְאוּרַת צִפְעוֹנִי (שם י"א) כָּל חֹר וּבֶקַע עָמֹק קְרוּי אוּר:

It is to this that the name of the place Ur-Kasdim (fire of the Chaldees) alludes (Genesis Rabbah 38:13).

Menachem ben Seruk, however, explains that אור *means a valley, as (Isaiah 24:15) "Glorify ye the Lord in the valleys (*באורים*)", and as (Isaiah 11:8) "the den (*מאורת*) of the basilisk".*

Every hole or deep cleft may be called אור.

יסכה.

זוֹ שָׂרָה, עַל שֵׁם שֶׁסּוֹכָה בְּרוּחַ הַקֹּדֶשׁ וְשֶׁהַכֹּל סוֹכִין בְּיָפְיָהּ; וְעוֹד יִסְכָּה לְשׁוֹן נְסִיכוּת, כְּמוֹ שָׂרָה לְשׁוֹן שְׂרָרָה:

יסכה *JISCAH — This was Sarah;*

she was also named Jiscah (from a root meaning ""to see", "to look") because she could see the future by holy inspiration, and because everybody looked (gazed) at her beauty (Megillah 14a).

*The name Jiscah also has reference to princely dignity (*נסיכות*) just as the name Sarah (*שרה*) has an allusion to "ruling"(*שררה*).*

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ויצאו אתם.

וַיֵּצְאוּ תֶּרַח וְאַבְרָם עִם לוֹט וְשָׂרַי:

ויצאו אתם *AND THEY WENT FORTH WITH THEM* — ויצאו אתם *Terah and Abram went forth with Lot and Sarai.*

וימת תרח בחרן.

לְאַחַר שֶׁיָּצָא אַבְרָם מֵחָרָן וּבָא לְאֶרֶץ כְּנַעַן, וְהָיָה שָׁם יוֹתֵר מִשִּׁשִּׁים שָׁנָה;

שֶׁהֲרֵי כָּתוּב וְאַבְרָם בֶּן חָמֵשׁ שָׁנִים וְשִׁבְעִים שָׁנָה בְּצֵאתוֹ מֵחָרָן וְתֶרַח בֶּן שִׁבְעִים שָׁנָה כְּשֶׁנּוֹלַד אַבְרָם, הֲרֵי קמ"ה לְתֶרַח;

וימת תרח בחרן *AND TERAH DIED IN HARAN after Abram had left Haran (as related in the next chapter) and had come to the land of Canaan and had been there more than sixty years.*

כְּשֶׁיָּצָא אַבְרָם מֵחָרָן עֲדַיִן נִשְׁאֲרוּ מִשְּׁנוֹתָיו הָרְבֵּה,

For it is written, (Genesis 12:4) "And Abram was seventy five years old when he left Haran", and Terah was seventy years old when Abram was born (Genesis 11:26), making Terah 145 years old when Abram left Haran, so that there were then many years of his life left (i. e. he lived many years after that — as a matter of fact, 60 years, as he was 205 years old when he died).

וְלָמָּה הִקְדִּים הַכָּתוּב מִיתָתוֹ שֶׁל תֶּרַח לִיצִיאָתוֹ שֶׁל אַבְרָם?

Why, then, does Scripture mention the death of Terah before the departure of Abram?

שֶׁלֹּא יְהֵא הַדָּבָר מְפֻרְסָם לַכֹּל וְיֹאמְרוּ לֹא קִיֵּם אַבְרָם אֶת כִּבּוּד אָבִיו, שֶׁהִנִּיחוֹ זָקֵן וְהָלַךְ לוֹ, לְפִיכָךְ קְרָאוֹ הַכָּתוּב מֵת,

שֶׁהָרְשָׁעִים אַף בְּחַיֵּיהֶם קְרוּיִים מֵתִים,

In order that this matter (his leaving home during his father's lifetime) might not become known to all, lest people should say that Abram did not show a son's respect to his father, for he left him in his old age and went his way.

וְהַצַּדִּיקִים אַף בְּמִיתָתָן קְרוּיִים חַיִּים,

That is why Scripture speaks of him as dead (Genesis Rabbah 39:7).

שֶׁנֶּאֱמַר וּבְנָיָהוּ בֶן יְהוֹיָדָע בֶּן אִישׁ חי (שְׁמוּאֵל ב' כ"ג):

For indeed the wicked even while alive are called dead and the righteous even when dead are called living, as it is said, (2 Samuel 23:20) "And Benaiah the son of Jehoiada the son of a living man".

(בחרן הַנּו"ן הֲפוּכָה לוֹמַר לְךָ, עַד

אַבְרָם חֲרוֹן אַף שֶׁל מָקוֹם):

בחרן *IN HARAN — The נ is inverted to tell you that until the time of Abraham, the fierce anger (חרון) of the Omnipotent was kindled against the world.*

HOW RASHI USES HIS SOURCES

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Four comments on one verse

All four spotlight comments cluster on a single verse — Genesis 11:7, הבה נרדה — and together they show Rashi's whole workshop. On הבה נרדה itself Rashi writes: 'He took counsel with His Judicial Court because of His exceeding meekness (Sanhedrin 38b).' The plural verb becomes an ethical tableau: God models humility by consulting. Rashi attributes the move to Sanhedrin 38b — the gemara's consultation motif, famous from 'let us make man' — transplanted onto a new verse. It is midrash as precedent: the same divine manners, a new occasion.

On the single word הבה Rashi compresses a whole midrash into a clause: 'measure for measure — they had said 'Come, let us build'; He meted out to them correspondingly, saying 'Come, let us go down' (Midrash Tanchuma, Noach 18).' The Tanchuma's wordplay on the repeated הבה is delivered as tight paraphrase, the source named and then absorbed. And on ולא ישמעו Rashi gives the midrash room to breathe: 'One asks for a brick and the other brings him lime: the former therefore attacks him and splits open his brains.' No source is named inside the comment; the vivid scene does the work — an unattributed compression that turns linguistic confusion into slapstick violence, and lets the punishment fit the crime of forced unity.

WORD STUDIES

Three words from the aliyah

Three load-bearing words from Genesis 11, each swept through the Historical Dictionary's full citation record. Note: CAL (cal.huc.edu) prohibits scraping, so Aramaic coverage here is Jastrow/BDB via Sefaria; the Hebrew sweeps below are Maagarim direct.

שָׁנָה

Klein · שנה

f.n.

— (dual שנתים, pl. שנים) year.

Jastrow · שינה

f.

— sleep. Ber. 3b מעולם לא עבר ... בש' midnight never found me asleep. Ib. 62b ש' בעמוד וכ' sleep at morning dawn (v. שינא I). Meg. 15b שנת וכ', v. נדד. Succ. 26a שינת, v. עראי. Ib. במוסר שינתו וכ' when he g

Jastrow · שנה

Maagarim

שנה — 30976 attestations, root שני 1 (שינוי והשתנות).

שנה — year. 30,976 attestations across 1,172 pages: one of the most documented nouns in Hebrew. It is first seen where time itself is instituted, Genesis 1:14 — the luminaries made

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'for days and years' — and then becomes the drumbeat of the genealogies: 'X lived N years and begot Y' (Genesis 5:3–4, and seventeen times in our aliyah). The quiet irony is the root: Maagarim files שנה under שני, change and alteration — a 'year' is literally a changing, time measured by what does not stay. Klein and Jastrow agree on the plain sense, and the sweep shows why: the word never needed to reinvent itself. It lands in modern Hebrew untouched, in Bialik's essays (1932–34) and Yitzhak Shami's 1937 prose ('במרוצת השנים'), still counting what changes. A word that names change and never changed.

יוֹלֶד

Jastrow · יולד

Jastrow · יולד

m. pl.

— יולדים (b. h.; parents. Keth. VII, 6 המקללת יולדיו בפניו she who curses his (her husband's) parents in his presence; quot. ib. 72[b] יולידיו (an emphatic form), and interpreted במקללת יולידיו בפני מולידיו (v

BDB · ילד

— vb. bear, bring forth, beget (NH id.; Aramaic יליד, יליד, ; Arabic bear, bring forth, so Ethiopic Assyrian alâdu, COTGloss)—

Maagarim

ילד [הפעיל] — 2094 attestations, root ילד 1 (הולדה, לידה).

ויולד — and he begot. 2,094 attestations of ילד in hifil; the aliyah's wayyiqtol form occurs 59 times in the corpus. First seen in Genesis 5:3 — Adam begets Seth 'in his likeness, after his image' — the formula that structures both great genealogies, Genesis 5 and our Genesis 11. Page 1 of the citation sweep is pure formula: all twenty citations from the Genesis 5 toledot, ויולד tolling like a metronome. The verb barely leaves the genealogy for millennia — and then lands, startlingly, in Bialik's 1923 essay, where ideas 'beget' cultural monstrosities ('שהולידו לנו את הסנדל המשונה'). From biological begetting to cultural begetting: the arc of a verb that learned metaphor late and never looked back.

יָלַד

BDB · ילד

— vb. bear, bring forth, beget (NH id.; Aramaic יליד, יליד, ; Arabic bear, bring forth, so Ethiopic Assyrian alâdu, COTGloss)—

BDB · לדה

— v. ילד, Inf. cstr.

Maagarim

ילד [הפעיל] — 2094 attestations, root ילד 1 (הולדה, לידה).

הולידו — his begetting. Maagarim resolves this to the same entry as ויולד (ילד [הפעיל], koderech 13361): one word, two grammatical lives. Where ויולד is the finite event — he begot — אחרי הולידו is the infinitive construct with suffix, the hinge of every genealogy entry: 'X lived N years and begot Y; and X lived after his begetting Y, M years.' Twenty-one

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occurrences of the infinitive form in the corpus. In the aliyah הוליד always looks backward, measuring the remainder of a life against its generative moment — the years after the begetting, when the name has been secured and only the living remains.

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